Cuba, for whose sake we are doing everything? Or retaliate with a nuclear strike, which would mean the initiation of the war?"[10]

Mikoyan received support from an unexpected quarter when Khrushchev asked the newly appointed ambassador to Havana, Aleksandr Alekseev, to join the meeting. "Comrade Alekseev, in order to help Cuba and save the Cuban revolution, we have decided to place rockets on the island," said Khrushchev, surprising the government's leading expert on Cuba. "What do you think of this? How will Fidel react? Will he give his agreement?" Alekseev, a KGB officer who was about to become a diplomat, summoned all his diplomatic skills and responded that Castro was spearheading campaigns all over Latin America against foreign military bases and trying to force the Americans to leave Guantánamo, so for him to accept a Soviet military base in Cuba would go against his own policies.

Khrushchev remained silent, but Marshal Malinovsky, whose Anadyr plan suddenly appeared to be in jeopardy, went on the offensive, trying to intimidate Alekseev. "What sort of revolution is it if, as you say, they do not agree?" yelled Malinovsky. "I fought in Spain, there was a bourgeois revolution there, but they accepted help from us even so.… And socialist Cuba has far more reason to do so!" If the Soviets were trying to rescue Cuba in order to save socialism, as Khrushchev had suggested, then, according to Malinovsky's logic, how could socialist Cuba refuse Soviet missiles? Faced with the ideological argument, Alekseev fell silent. But Kozlov, Khrushchev's chief deputy in the party, defended Alekseev: Castro's support of Khrushchev's bold initiative could not be taken for granted. Khrushchev, for his part, wanted Alekseev to help the Soviet political and military delegation that was going to Havana convince Castro to accept the nuclear missiles.[11]

Khrushchev proposed a compromise of sorts. He suggested pushing ahead with preparations while delaying a final decision on the launch of the mission. He told Mikoyan: "Let's not talk about it anymore. We will ask Fidel Castro and then we will decide. We will send [Marshal Sergei] Biriuzov with his specialists to check if there are spots to hide missile launchers to make them invisible to the aircraft." Ivanov scribbled in his notes: "The Presidium members and those who spoke agreed and approved the decision. Decision: approve Operation Anadyr completely and